challenges indicate that the two supreme leaders have both stoked nationalist fervour rather than dampened it.

Another confrontation along the border is therefore quite possible. Until the mid-1980s, China had signalled that it was principally concerned about the eastern sector. After 1985, it made clear that it regards both sectors as important, with perhaps the western sector somewhat more important. The Doklam crisis and the confrontation at Naku La in Sikkim in May 2020 suggest that the Sikkim area too is brittle. Only the middle sector has been incident-free in the past several years. However, as we saw, the first military incidents between India and China were in Barahoti in 1954 in this central part of the disputed border, and so nothing is certain even there. In 2020, reports emerged of Beijing's actions in Tibet to disperse rural Tibetans and move towards re-education camps for them on the model of the Uighurs in Xinjiang. China remains nervous about Tibet's future, and that means serious disturbances in the province will affect military behaviour along the India–China boundary. A post–Dalai Lama Tibet could become unstable, which could lead to tensions along the border.

Will India and China fight now or in the foreseeable future? As we will see in our discussion of the India–China power balance, full-scale war is unlikely. While the Chinese military is certainly superior, geography mitigates the imbalance. Neither side has the ability to strike deep into the other's territory and sustain its advance. Provided that the Indian military gets its deployments and tactics right, that it is able to move supplies efficiently, and that morale remains high among the officers and troops, it will be able to deter a Chinese attack. If an attack nevertheless occurs, Indian forces should be able to hold, particularly in a short war. The great uncertainty is whether China's military reforms, featuring integrated commands and the development of high-technology weaponry, have gone far enough to give it a decisive edge. The other uncertainty is the role of nuclear weapons in a war. As we will see later, they will probably not come into play, at least in part because India's ability to use nuclear weapons in a fight with China is still very limited.